

## Chapter 17

### Instructor's Manual

#### This chapter covers:

- How the court system blocked a California voter-approved bill to allow housing discrimination in the 1960s
- A list of discriminatory housing practices that are prohibited by law
- A description of housing discrimination in the Latino community after Hurricane Katrina and the methods that agencies use to investigate linguistic profiling
- Baugh's study which explores whether listeners can judge a person's race or ethnicity based on a speaking voice alone
- Baugh's study to investigate accent discrimination in housing (specifically discrimination against speakers of AAVE and ChE)
- Housing discrimination against Muslims in the U.S.

#### Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

##### From the textbook

1. Watch the advertisement produced by the Equal Housing Authority on linguistic profiling, in which an Anglo makes phone call after phone call about an advertisement for an apartment; with each call he uses a different stigmatized accent. An informal survey of my own indicates that the average person can identify all the accents (which does not, of course, mean that the accents are technically accurate; it may be that individuals recognize the portrayal of an accent). There are Asian and Middle Eastern accents included, though there has been no formal investigation of how such accents are profiled in day-to-day telephone interaction. How might such an investigation look? [http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=c\\_3mSW8XUZI](http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=c_3mSW8XUZI)

**Sample answer:** I imagine that researchers could design a study similar to Baugh's investigation of accent discrimination in housing-related phone calls. The researcher(s) could have people with Asian and Middle Eastern accents make calls to businesses asking for some information and compare those calls with ones made by Anglo, \*SAE-speaking participants to see how the interactions differ based on the caller's accent.

2. Imagine that you have a friend or coworker who applied for an apartment and has been the victim of linguistic profiling, in your view of things. He or she is reluctant to register a complaint. Investigate the process and put together the information and forms that your friend will need to pursue the issue. Consider the following issues:

- a. Does this process strike you as reasonable, or overly complicated?
- b. Why might an otherwise intelligent, well established individual be reluctant to pursue equal treatment under the law?

**Sample answer:** From what I can see on the HUD website for filing housing discrimination complaints, the beginning stages of the process seem straightforward—you can fill out an online form (although you only have 45 minutes to complete the form before being timed out) or mail in a complaint to the office nearest you. I think people might be reluctant to complain either because they don't realize they've been discriminated against based on their accent, they feel embarrassed to complain because they're not sure if they really experienced discrimination, or they don't consider accent discrimination to be “real” discrimination.

*3. Read some of the articles about linguistic profiling provided. How would you describe the tone: Any hint of an ideological leaning in one direction or another?*

**Sample answer:** I think the tone and the content of the articles demonstrate an ideological leaning in opposition to the practices of linguistic profiling and housing discrimination. For example, the articles seem to treat these practices as real social problems and do not provide any arguments that claim this kind of discrimination does not exist.

*4. Can you recall any instances of linguistic profiling over the phone? Judgments made about the stranger on the other end? Reactions?*

**Sample answer:** I have had very little experience working in jobs where I had to answer phone calls from the public, so the vast majority of the calls I answer are from people I know. However, I do make calls to businesses and interact with strangers on the phone in that context. I do notice the language variety that the customer service reps speak, so I do place each speaker into social categories based on race, age, gender, etc., but I truly hope I have never treated anybody differently based on their language variety.

*5. Recently a major computer manufacturer announced a new policy in customer support. For a significant annual fee, customers would be guaranteed a native English speaker on the other end of the line. That is, the call would not be routed to a call center in India or Pakistan. What are the implications here? Could this practice be illegal, or is it simply a fee-for-service arrangement? What does this have to do with voice profiling?*

**Sample answer:** The implication here is that speaking with a native speaker of English would a better customer service experience, so therefore customers who want this “superior” customer service will have to pay more money. This practice is related to linguistic profiling because when customers call a help line and are connected to someone with a foreign accent, they frequently expect the service to be unhelpful.

I am not sure if this practice is illegal or not since the people being discriminated against are living in another country, but I think it would be illegal if customers could pay more money to make sure they interacted with native speakers in the U.S. rather than Americans who speak English with an accent. Since I think it would probably be illegal here in the United States, I think that makes it a pretty shady practice to be done anywhere.

## From the website

### Audio

*1. Listen to the samples of the language varieties discussed in this chapter. Do you think you could identify the races or ethnicities of these speakers? How confident are you that you can identify racial or ethnic information about strangers on the phone?*

**Sample answer:** For most of these samples I think I could identify the language variety that is associated with a racial or ethnic group, and from there I could make an assumption about the person's race. For example, I could identify Kentucky 4 as a speaker of AAVE, and therefore I might assume that she is African American. However, I couldn't be *certain* that she was African American just because she speaks AAVE – she could be an AAVE speaker of any race. Therefore, I have to say that I think I can identify language varieties associated with race or ethnicity rather than race or ethnicity itself.

### Video

“Eddie Pinder: Linguistic Profiling”

ABC News, 07/12/2007

<http://abcnews.go.com/WNT/Video/playerIndex?id=3372801>

*1. What do you think about James Johnson's case? Evaluate the arguments of the plaintiff and the defendant. Whose argument do you find more convincing and why?*

**Sample answer:** I think it is pretty clear based on the evidence presented in this video clip that James Johnson was discriminated against because he sounded African American. His non-AAVE speaking friend was called back, as were all the white test callers who investigated the apartment complex, whereas Johnson and all the black test callers were ignored. To me, it really seems like that the apartment complex does not want to rent apartments to African Americans. I am very skeptical of any reason the defendant might present for why none of the black callers were called back if the defendant did not know they were black.

*2. If court cases like this one are successful, how do you think they might affect linguistic discrimination in general? Why do you feel the way you do?*

**Sample answer:** I have hope that if these kinds of linguistic discrimination cases get widespread media attention, maybe people will start reevaluating their negative responses to dialects and accents. I am not sure what kinds of effects these cases would have on people's standard language ideologies, but perhaps with growing awareness of linguistic discrimination, people may question at least some aspects of standard language ideologies and be more tolerant of non-standard language varieties.

### Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Try to recreate Baugh's first linguistic profiling experiment to see how accurate people at your university are at identifying race/ethnicity. You can use the Linguistic Profiling Test (<http://www.uiowa.edu/~c103112/lingprof.html>) or you can create your own recordings.
2. Try to recreate Baugh's second linguistic profiling experiment to investigate linguistic discrimination in your area. Recruit people who speak language varieties associated with different races and ethnicities from inside or outside of class and ask them to call businesses to make identical inquiries. Analyze the results as a class and discuss them in light of what the students have learned in this chapter and in the course as a whole.
3. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.